

Fox Kloske

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Cartography as Conquest: Matrakçı Nasuh and Imperial Ottoman Identity

Urban history emerges from a fundamental quality of the city: Its urban fabric is forever evolving. If the physical city itself is the first source for this “inherently visual undertaking,” then historical urban representations suggest how spaces were constructed, navigated, and perceived by people across time.¹ These visual representations are plentiful in 16th century Euro-Mediterranean discourse, and, according to Kafescioğlu, “a larger trend of the early modern era in which the Ottoman world partook.”² Matrakçı Nasuh (1480 - c. 1564), a Janissary military strategist and court historian, participated in this trend with his work *Beyan-ı Menazil-i Sefer-i Irakeyn* (c. 1537). Gifted to Süleyman the Magnificent, the 117 depictions of cities create a visual narrative of the Sultan’s Iraqi campaign against the Safavids.³ In addition to documenting a historical event, these travel itineraries, as Ay Ak describes, “enabled the audience to see and imagine places that were not otherwise visible...[creating] the desire to travel and explore these places.”⁴ However, the opening two-page image of Constantinople (fig. 1), the capital of the Ottoman Empire and home to the imperial residence, raises questions of its inclusion (considering the patron’s deep familiarity with the city, for example). Building upon the narrative of conquest, the selective knowledge conveyed within these images—the choices of inclusion

¹ Kathryn Ebel, “Visual Sources for Urban History of the Ottoman Empire,” *Türkiye Araştırmaları Literatur Dergisi* (2005): 457.

² Çiğdem Kafescioğlu, “Ottoman Images of Istanbul in the Age of Empire: The View from the Heavens, the View from the Street,” *Arts and Images in Istanbul* (2010): 314.

³ Kafescioğlu, “View from the Heavens,” 317.

⁴ Betül Rüveyda Ay Ak and Ayça Çağlayan, “Space and Human Representation in Miniature Art: The Ottoman Empire-Matrakçı Nasuh Works,” *International Studies and Evaluations in the Field of Landscape Architecture* (2024): 64.

and omission—are vehicles to “[project] the ideological and political considerations of their author and patron,” Emiralioğlu writes.⁵ Through the map's inclusion and composition, Matrakçı's depiction of Constantinople serves a strategic function: to redefine the city in terms of Ottoman imperialism, presenting Constantinople as the capital of universal sovereignty.

While the work itself was made in collaboration with the many painters and illustrators working of the palace scriptorium, Matrakçı is given credit, by Ay Ak, for instance, as “the first to create the concept of ‘topographic depiction.’”⁶⁷ Indeed, the images in the *Beyan-ı Menazil-i Sefer-i Irakeyn* are stylistically unique: Each combine Ottoman painting, nautical cartography, and a ‘bird’s-eye-view,’ without, as Ebel writes, “eluding easy inclusion in any of these three genres”⁸ Central to the distinct composition of the work is the format of viewership; as an image within a book, it invites a dynamic element, encouraging the viewer to navigate the work by looking down upon it (rather than head-on like a hung painting).⁹ As the viewer looks down upon the page, the image looks down upon the city, a vantage at the time only possible through imagination. This top-down view allows for Matrakçı to present his image as a comprehensive representation of the city, suggesting that what is shown encompasses its entirety. This claim to totality, according to Kafescioğlu, however, is “independent of the image’s accuracy or facticity,” for the set of choices of what is included, omitted, or emphasized reflect not an objective documentation of space, but a curated vision.¹⁰

⁵ Pinar Emiralioğlu, “Other Places: Ottomans traveling, seeing, writing, drawing the world,” *Osmanlı Araştırmaları: The Journal of Ottoman Studies* (2012): 163.

⁶ Ebel, “Visual Sources for Urban History,” 463.

⁷ Ay Ak, “Space and Human Representation,” 65.

⁸ Ebel, “Visual Sources for Urban History,” 462.

⁹ Ay Ak, “Space and Human Representation,” 64.

¹⁰ Kafescioğlu, “View from the Heavens,” 317.

Matrakçı's curated vision is apparent through his construction of urban space.

Perspective, the linear technique of representing three dimensional objects on a two dimensional surface, is not employed. Instead, as Ay Ak describes, Matrakçı presents Constantinople "by depicting the objects within it," rather than the space itself.¹¹ Huseyin Zahit Selvi, a geomatic engineer, in his article "A Cartographic Analysis of Matrakçı Nasuh's Miniatures," supports this interpretation of Matrakçı's technique; compared with satellite imagery, he determines poor planimetric accuracy (the specific positioning of features), but high topological accuracy (the spatial relationships between features).¹² While Pera, Galata, and a sliver of Üsküdar are depicted, the majority of these features appear on the right side of the page inside Constantinople's walls. For example, the Hagia Sophia, the Bayezid Mosque, the Old Palace, and Mehmed II's mosque complex fall along the same vertical axis. The Topkapı Palace and the historical hippodrome surround the Hagia Sophia at the tip of the peninsula. Each of these specific features are devoted considerable detail in contrast to the repetition of uses throughout the rest of the city, rendered with bright red roofs. Kafescioğlu describes this effort: "Looking at any one segment of the painting, the viewer will see a number of religious and charitable buildings, baths, markets, and residences"¹³ Matrakçı's presentation of space projects a uniform identity onto the city, disrupted only by a central axis of important structures of the Ottoman empire.

Central to this visual identity is the prominence of Islamic iconography in the represented city. As part of the larger effort to redefine Constantinople as a Muslim city, Kafescioğlu

¹¹ Ay Ak, "Space and Human Representation," 64.

¹² Huseyin Zahit Selvi and Gaye Bekiroglu Keskin, "A Cartographic Analysis of Matrakçı Nasuh's Miniatures," *The Cartographic Journal* (2019): 280.

¹³ Kafescioğlu, "View from the Heavens," 316.

describes Matrakçı's work as "silenc[ing] the presence of Byzantine and non-Muslim buildings."¹⁴ For example, the Hagia Sophia, built by Byzantine Emperor Justinian I, is depicted with two minarets; the ruins of the Hippodrome, once a staple of the Byzantine capital, are nearly unnoticeable. In addition to the Hagia Sophia, three smaller former Byzantine churches are represented, now converted into mosques.¹⁵ In contrast, Venetian artists of this period instead highlight the Byzantine heritage of the city. Niccoló Guidalotto (c. 1636-1670), despite representing Constantinople more than one hundred years further removed from the Byzantine reign, in his panorama of Constantinople (fig. 2) exclusively captions structures belonging to the city's Byzantine history. Derby identifies "a major emphasis on Hagia Sophia, marked by its Latin name (Sancta Sophia)."¹⁶ Indeed, the inclusion or omission of religious monuments "highlights the way in which the city was appropriated by either Christians or Ottomans."¹⁷ Through a composition that foregrounds the multiplicity of domes and minarets, Matrakçı's work presents an Islamic identity onto the urban fabric: Islamic authority is omnipresent and visually unchallenged.

Alongside this emphasis on religious identity, the visual prominence of the Topkapı Palace underscores the dynastic character of Matrakçı's Constantinople. When Mehmed II conquered Constantinople from the Byzantines in 1453, he ordered a large imperial palace to be built in the center of the city. Avcioglu describes this construction as "symbolic as well as physical appropriation of the conquered land," that legitimizes Mehmed II as the Muslim ruler of

¹⁴ Kafescioğlu, "View from the Heavens," 319.

¹⁵ Kafescioğlu, "View from the Heavens," 319.

¹⁶ Nirit Ben-Aryeh Derby, "A Venetian View of Constantinople: Mapping the City," *Portraits of the City: Representing Urban Space in Later Medieval and Early Modern Europe* (2014): 170.

¹⁷ Derby, "Venetian View of Constantinople," 161.

Constantinople.¹⁸ The Topkapı, however, commissioned only shortly after the now Old Palace's completion, served a separate role for the city's identity. If the Old Palace was the means of securing the religious identity of the newly conquered city, then the New Palace was the means of placing the city into a specific Ottoman imperial identity—Avcioğlu suggests that the creation of the Topkapı in itself indicates that the “topographic sign of Muslim authority was not in itself sufficient for the Ottoman Imperial identity of the city.”¹⁹ Architecturally, the palace draws from Ottoman imperial encampments and sits atop a commanding landscape—one of the many visual cues that tie it to the urban fabric of the imperial city it occupies; in that way, Avcioğlu describes, “the Topkapi Palace has evolved and connected in its own idiosyncratic terms with each new urban episteme surrounding it.”²⁰ Matrakçı supports this imperial relationship by rendering the palace with noticeable care; Kafescioğlu prescribes the complex a “conspicuous presence” within the composition.²¹ Compared to the Old Palace, the complex occupies a significantly larger footprint and is illustrated with more detail. The surrounding city walls are distinctively brighter than the rest of the city. Through these visual choices, the Topkapı Palace emerges as more than a sultanic residence: It becomes the genesis of imperial Ottoman power, anchoring the capital in a dynastic and visual imperial order.

In addition to interpreting Ottoman imperialism spatially, Matrakçı's potent visualization places the city within imperial time. As the genesis of imperialism, the image of Constantinople carried with it, according to Ebel, “the image of the Ottoman Empire as a whole.”²² For that reason, Matrakçı's map is a product of a period of conflict, both physical and ideological.

¹⁸ Nebahat Avcioğlu, “Istanbul: The Palimpsest City in Search of Its Architext,” *RES: Anthropology and Aesthetics* (2008): 193.

¹⁹ Avcioğlu, “The Palimpsest City,” 193.

²⁰ Avcioğlu, “The Palimpsest City,” 192.

²¹ Kafescioğlu, “View from the Heavens,” 316.

²² Ebel, “Visual Sources for Urban History,” 463.

Mirroring the push and pull of borders to the east and west, the cultural meaning of Constantinople, in Kafescioğlu's words, "was a central concern for Western and Ottoman realms alike, and...in the process of being re-made."²³ The garden-like city depicted by Matrakçı—with strikingly blue water, shades of green across hills, and an assortment of colorful trees—presents itself, however, not as a city in struggle. Instead, uniform visual cues present a city of unity, with the historically European community of Pera and the Asian side of the Bosphorus, Üsküdar, oriented to face the city of Constantinople. Eleven ships in the Golden Horn and Bosphorus suggest a wide trade network project an image of mobility and access that transcends imperial borders. By presenting the city, in its whole, as uniform, Muslim, and imperial, Matrakçı erases instability and demonstrates control. In doing so, he aligns with the broader effort to legitimize "Ottoman claims to universal imperial sovereignty."²⁴ Constantinople, as Matrakçı presents it, is an example of imperial stability in a fluctuating world.

Matrakçı's map of Constantinople responds to the specific political and ideological influence of its time. In addition to Matrakçı, "travelers, historians, sea captains, cartographers, and astrologers" created this distinct body of imperial-promoting geographical literature.²⁵ However, the true value of a contextual framework emerges from the diverse interpretations of the city. Piri Reis, a contemporary cartographer of Matrakçı, had a unique style born out of a distinctive purpose: his maps, as Ebel describes, were "produced in a tradition of practical cartography intended for orientation, way-finding, or navigation."²⁶ Regardless of the difference, Reis' work was valued, "with his rapid promotion in the Ottoman military hierarchy...as a

²³ Kafescioğlu, "View from the Heavens," 317.

²⁴ Emirlioğlu, "Other Places," 168.

²⁵ Emirlioğlu, "Other Places," 169.

²⁶ Ebel, "Visual Sources for Urban History," 459.

testimony.”²⁷ These differences in cartographic approaches demonstrate the flexibility of mapmaking as a tool for political expression, both responding to and shaping the world they represent. Matrakçı’s Constantinople is an imaginative construction—a vision of imperial, religious, and dynastic dominance. His map represents more than the physical city that was seen, but what the Ottoman imperial elite wanted to see. In that way, maps do not simply document space, they project values, ideologies, and ambitions. As Piri Reis mapped the Mediterranean for navigation, Matrakçı mapped Constantinople for authority—both an effort to assert order over a disorderly world. Through this understanding, the study of cartography is not one of accuracy, but of perspective: Matrakçı’s work is a striking example of cartography as conquest.

²⁷ Emiralioğlu, “Other Places,” 167.

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Figure 1. Matrakçı Nasuh. *Map of Constantinople* from *Beyan-ı Menazil-i Sefer-i Irakeyn*. c. 1537. Istanbul, Topkapı Palace Museum Library. Ink, watercolor, and gold on paper.



Figure 2. Niccoló Guidalotto da Mondavio. *Panorama of Constantinople*. c. 1662. Venice, Biblioteca Nazionale Marciana. Engraving on paper.